right to grow. **When enterprises embed resilience and embrace anti-fragility, they fortify the nation's foundation and position it to rise stronger with every adversity.**

Third, businesses must advance a paradigm of Compassionate Capitalism. Competitiveness gives enterprises the power to win, anti-fragility the right to win the future and purpose the legitimacy to win. Businesses exist to serve both an economic and social purpose. The enormous climate risks, livelihood challenges, inequality and regulations **make it a crucial responsibility of businesses to embed sustainability and inclusion as an integral component of strategy.** This belief lies at the core of your Company's approach.

> **When enterprises embed resilience and embrace anti-fragility, they fortify the nation's foundation and position it to rise stronger with every adversity.**

A few years ago, your Company laid the foundations of the **ITC Next strategy** to drive scale, accelerated growth and profitability and make the enterprise even more future-ready. Guided by the Company's credo of **"Nation First, *Sab Saath Badhein*", our north-star is to create growing value for all our stakeholders — by building national competitiveness that is globally benchmarked, resilience that is locally anchored, and growth that is anti-fragile, inclusive and sustainable.**

ITC: Ushering in NextGen Agri, Strengthening Rural India

I begin with agriculture — the lifeline of our economy and the foundation of rural India. India possesses vast arable land, diverse agro-climatic zones and leadership in several commodities. Yet, low productivity, fragmented holdings, limited value addition, climate vulnerability and inefficient market access continue to constrain its potential. This points to a defining opportunity to **transform Indian agriculture from volume-led production to value-led competitiveness,** not only to fortify food security but to raise farmer incomes, deepen rural capability and enhance exports.

The Government has spearheaded several commendable measures to support growth of the agri-food sector. Higher farmer incomes can trigger a virtuous cycle of consumption, investment, employment and rural prosperity. This requires a structural shift to shape **NextGeneration Agriculture** — from fragmented productivity to integrated competitiveness, from undifferentiated commodities to high-value agriculture, and from vulnerable farming systems to climate-smart, technology-enabled rural ecosystems.

> **There is a defining opportunity to transform Indian agriculture from volume-led production to value-led competitiveness.... ITCMAARS has onboarded over 2.6 million farmers across 11 States, with the ambition to benefit 10 million farmers by 2030.**

With over a century of engagement with agriculture, 94% of your Company's businesses are linked to agri-crops or plantations, generating substantial livelihoods. ITC nurtures **21 value chains across 23 States to source nearly 6 million tonnes of agri-produce.** In this address, I will focus on ITC's Agri Business, which is now the country's largest private sector agri-enterprise, **doubling segment revenue in just over 5 years to nearly ₹20,300 crore** in FY26. The **ITC Next strategy** is today transforming the Agri Business, while ushering in NextGeneration farming and rural empowerment.

At the core of this transformation is the **ITCMAARS** phygital ecosystem, designed to empower FPOs with digital technologies, hyper-personalised advisories, quality inputs, market linkages, scientific agronomy and climate-smart practices to improve farm competitiveness and resilience. In a short span, ITCMAARS has onboarded **over 2.6 million farmers** across 11 States, with the ambition to benefit 10 million farmers by 2030. Initial estimates indicate **crop yield gains of 15–20% and improvement in net returns by 25–30%.**

Building on a recent horticulture pilot, anchored by FPOs, for the supply of high-quality fruits and vegetables, ITC plans to develop 4 additional hybrid Open-to-Sky and Controlled Environment Agriculture clusters to create a reliable, traceable supply chain for fresh produce. Progressively, **ITCMAARS is introducing precision-led agriculture and advanced agri-tech solutions, like IoT-enabled weather tracking, remote-sensing, drone-based services, to promote smart farming.**

A vital component of your Company's agri strategy is to promote **Value-Added Agriculture** to enable farmers scale the next horizon of profitable growth. This portfolio, which has grown at a CAGR of 33% over five years, today encompasses **certified organic crops, processed agri-products, such as food-safe spices, horticulture, premium coffee, aquaculture and attribute-specific commodities, like high-starch maize and high-gluten wheat.**

Taking this further, ITCMAARS will drive a Farming as a Service (FaaS) ecosystem to 'Grow the Buy', where crop value chains are customised to meet specific buyer needs. Certifications, traceability and responsible sourcing establish **trust systems at scale,** linking Indian farmers to domestic and global export markets. ITC's Spices Business, for example, is today the country's leading exporter of organic spices, supported by certified cultivation, backward integration and **one of Asia's largest spices processing facilities at Guntur.**

In an era of climate stress and rising food security imperatives, production of **high-quality, resilient seeds and hybrids** is vital to enhancing productivity, improving quality, increasing climate resilience, strengthening nutritional security and raising farmer incomes. Your Company's wholly owned subsidiary **Technico, a global leader in pre-basic potato seeds, is investing in the world's largest state-of-the-art aeroponic facility** with 60 hi-tech controlled-environment greenhouses, taking the combined capacity to 100 million TECHNITUBER®s.

Fostering an effective **science-to-farm ecosystem**, ITC's LSTC is leveraging advanced breeding technologies, molecular genetics and digital tools to develop higher-yielding, climate-resilient, hybrid and disease-resistant varieties across crops such as tobacco, wheat, potato, eucalyptus and subabul. **These have led to yields improving by 15-50%.**